C2 Reading

Irony and understatement

Read between the lines: when writers say less, or the opposite, of what they mean.

At C2, the hardest reading questions are about tone. Writers in journalism, reviews and fiction often mean more than, or the opposite of, what their words literally say.

Device	Example	Real meaning
Understatement	*The hotel was not exactly spotless.*	It was dirty.
Litotes (a negative to express a positive)	*Her performance was not bad at all.*	It was very good.
Verbal irony	*Another two-hour delay. Brilliant.*	This is terrible.
Overstatement for irony	*The minister's three-word answer was a masterpiece of detail.*	The answer said almost nothing.
Scare quotes	*The "renovated" kitchen had no oven.*	The writer does not accept the word.

Check for a mismatch. Irony usually shows a clash between the words and the facts around them. If praise sits next to bad news, read it again.

Common mistake. Taking polite British understatement literally. *It's a bit of a problem* can mean the situation is serious.

Text

> The launch of the new app went about as smoothly as these things usually do. Within an hour, the "intuitive" login page had locked out half of its users, and the help line, staffed by a single cheerful robot, was a model of efficiency, answering every question with the same apology. Still, the company's statement that the day had been "a learning experience" was, if nothing else, accurate.

Practice

1. What does *about as smoothly as these things usually do* suggest?
2. Why is *intuitive* in quotation marks?
3. What is ironic about *a model of efficiency*?
4. What does the writer mean by *if nothing else, accurate*?
5. Overall tone: (a) admiring (b) sarcastic (c) neutral

▼ **Show answers**

1. That it did not go smoothly at all; launches often go wrong.
2. They are scare quotes: the writer thinks the page was not intuitive.
3. Giving everyone the same apology is useless, the opposite of efficient.
4. The only true thing about the statement is that the company had a lot to learn, because so much went wrong.
5. (b) sarcastic